Jacqueline's Recreation of David Card's

1990 Study on the Mariel Boatlift and the Miami Labor Market

Jacqueline McGough

2026-11-03

Table of contents

Abstract 1
About This Project 1
Introduction 2
Data 2
Method 2
Results 2
References 3

Abstract

This project recreates David Card's 1990 study of the Mariel Boatlift and its impact on the Miami labor market. The original study asked how a sudden influx of Cuban immigrants affected wages and unemployment in Miami. Card compared Miami with a set of other cities before and after 1980 using a difference-in-differences design. This recreation applies the same design to Current Population Survey (CPS) data, shows the math behind the estimates, and reports the results.

About This Project

I'm doing this project as my entry into both economics and data science. It's my first project of this kind, and it's a way to teach myself the tools and math that practitioners in both fields use.

- **Language and libraries:** Python, with pandas, numpy, and matplotlib for the analysis.
- **Reporting:** Quarto, to produce HTML, PDF, and slide versions of the write-up from the same source.
- **Notebooks:** Jupyter notebooks, later on, to show the code alongside the results.

I hope to learn more about the Mariel Boatlift and its effect on Miami, about Card's study and its influence on labor economics, and about the statistical methods behind both.

Introduction

In 1980, the Mariel Boatlift brought roughly 125,000 Cuban immigrants to Miami within a few months, raising the city's labor force by about 7%. This led to concerns that local workers, especially those with less education, would see lower wages and higher unemployment.

Card treated the boatlift as a natural experiment. He compared Miami with a set of other cities that did not experience a similar influx (Atlanta, Houston, Los Angeles, and Tampa-St. Petersburg), using CPS data from 1979 to 1985. This let him compare how outcomes changed in Miami before and after the boatlift against how they changed in the comparison cities over the same period.

He looked at wages and unemployment for several groups of workers, including Black workers, white workers, and Hispanic workers. His findings suggested that the boatlift had little measurable effect on the wages or unemployment of existing workers in Miami, which challenged the conventional view that large immigration inflows necessarily hurt local labor markets.

The study has been highly influential in the debate over the economic effects of immigration, and it has been revisited several times since (for example, Borjas 2017 and Peri and Yasenov 2019).

On a personal note, doing this project has really helped me learn about what I want to do in my life and I can't believe how much I've enjoyed the process of creating this project. I hope to continue doing projects like this and to keep learning about economics, and data science.

Data

To be added: description of the CPS extract, sample restrictions, and variable definitions.

Method

To be added: the difference-in-differences model and the math behind it.

Results

To be added.

References

- Card, D. (1990). The Impact of the Mariel Boatlift on the Miami Labor Market. *Industrial and Labor Relations Review*, 43(2), 245-257.
- Borjas, G. J. (2017). The Wage Impact of the Marielitos: A Reappraisal. *Industrial and Labor Relations Review*, 70(5), 1077-1110.
- Peri, G., and Yasenov, V. (2019). The Labor Market Effects of a Refugee Wave: Synthetic Control Method Meets the Mariel Boatlift. *Journal of Human Resources*, 54(2), 267-309.